

Compound time

Compound time refers to the meters where the beat is subdivided into three parts instead of the more usual two. For this to be possible, the beat is always a dotted note, such as a dotted quarter note.

SEE ALSO

◀ 26–27 Note values

◀ 28–29 Beams and dots

◀ 30–31 Time signatures

Grouping notes

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Dotted quarter notes

Compound time signatures are an exception to the rule about the bottom number. For instance, in 6/8 there are six eighth notes in the measure, but the beat isn't a eighth note, it's a dotted quarter note worth three eighth notes with two beats in each measure. Similarly, 9/8 time has three dotted quarter notes in each measure, and 12/8 has four.

▷ 6/8, 9/8, 12/8

These three time signatures are all compound time meters, with each beat being a dotted quarter note.

Diagram illustrating compound time signatures (6/8, 9/8, 12/8) and their beat subdivisions. The notation shows measures with dotted quarter notes, indicating that each dotted quarter note is one beat. Annotations include: 'Six eighth notes in the measure' (pointing to the 6/8 signature), 'Denotes eighth note beats' (pointing to the 8 in the signature), and 'Each dotted quarter note is one beat.' (pointing to a dotted quarter note).

Simple time, compound time

The meters 2/4, 3/4, and 4/4 are examples of simple time. The beat can be subdivided into two—each quarter note divides into two eighth notes. 6/8, 9/8, and 12/8 are compound time signatures. Each beat in these time signatures is divided into three. It is helpful to compare 3/4 with 6/8, because they have the same number of eighth notes in each measure, but the note value of the beat and the way it subdivides are different.

Diagram illustrating simple time (3/4) and compound time (6/8) signatures. The notation shows measures with quarter notes and eighth notes, indicating the beat and subdivisions. The 3/4 measures show three beats per measure, each subdividing into two eighth notes. The 6/8 measures show two beats per measure, each subdividing into three eighth notes. The 6/8 measures are highlighted with a yellow background.

9

◁ Simple time

This example shows the beats and subdivisions in 3/4 time. There are three beats per measure, each subdividing into two eighth notes.

10

◁ Compound time

Shown here are the beats and subdivisions in 6/8 time. There are two beats per measure, each subdividing into three eighth notes.